

Through the Eyes of Travelers

- Travelers' motivations: escape disaster, trade, pilgrimage, adventure.
- **Accounts of Travelers:** Written records covering religious issues, architectural features, court affairs, and social practices.
- Aim of this chapter: To understand Medieval India through the accounts of Al-Biruni, Ibn Battuta, and Francois Bernier.

Al-Biruni (973-1048)

- Born in Khwarazm, Uzbekistan.
- Polymath: Physics, Maths, Astronomy, Natural Science, History.
- Multilingual: Syriac, Arabic, Persian, Hebrew, Sanskrit.
- Brought to Ghazni as a hostage by Sultan Mahmud.
- **Al-Biruni and India:**
 - Appointed state astrologer in Ghazni.
 - Interacted with Indians and Indian texts in Punjab (part of Ghaznavid Empire).
 - Accompanied Mahmud on invasions; spent significant time in India.
 - Learned Sanskrit and studied Brahminical texts on philosophy and religion.
 - Considered the founder of Indology.

Kitab-ul-Hind

- **Language:** Arabic.
- **Content:** 80 chapters on religion, philosophy, festivals, astronomy, alchemy, manners, customs, social life, weights & measures, iconography, laws, and metrology.
- **Format:** Distinctive structure for each chapter: A Question → Description → Comparison → Conclusion.

Al-Biruni's Observations of India

- **Barriers:**
 1. **Language:** Sanskrit was difficult.
 2. **Religious Beliefs & Practices:** Differences with his own.
 3. **Local Pride:** Indians' self-pride in their culture made it difficult to observe "dark aspects."
- **Sources Referred:** Vedas, Puranas, Bhagavad Gita, works of Patanjali, Manusmriti.
- **Description of Caste System:**
 - Disapproved of the concept of social stratification.
 - Viewpoint influenced by Brahmanical writings, sometimes differing from reality.
 - Compared to ancient Persian society's social divisions: Knights & Princes, Monks/Priests/Lawyers, Physicians/Astronomers/Scientists, Peasants & Artisans.

Ibn Battuta (1304-1377)

- Born in Tangier, Morocco.
- Studied Sharia and Islamic texts in a scholar family.
- Traveled over 117,000 KMs globally.
- **Brief Itinerary:** North & East Africa, Syria, Iraq, Persia, Yemen, Oman, Anatolia, Central Asia, China, Indonesia, Maldives.
- **Arrival in India:** Reached Sind via Central Asia in 1333.
- **In the Court of Tughlaq:**
 - Reached Delhi in 1334 via Multan.
 - Appointed Qazi (Judge) of Delhi by Muhammad Bin Tughlaq due to his knowledge.
 - Left India in 1342 as an envoy to China.
 - Traveled to China via South India, Maldives (remained Qazi for 18 months), Sri Lanka, and Indonesia.

Rihala (Travelogue of Battuta)

- **Language:** Arabic.
- **Content:** Records his observations of new and strange cultures, peoples, beliefs, values.
- Considered one of the richest travelogues globally.
- **Legacy:** Influenced many travelers from Central Asia and Persia (1400-1800) like Abdur Razzak Samarqandi, Mahmud Wali Balkhi, Shaikh Ali Hazin.
- **Travel in Medieval Era:** Hazardous and uncertain; travelers faced robbers, homesickness, loneliness.
- **Observations:** Minute observations of culture, food, weather, communication, cities, and rulers.

Ibn Battuta and Indian Cities

- **General Description:** Indian towns were full of opportunity and wealth for those with drive, resources, and skills. Crowded

streets, huge variety of goods in markets.

- **Description of Delhi (Tughlaqabad):**
 - Largest city in India, with a large population.
 - Rampart (fortification wall) was wide and long, containing storehouses, ammunition, magazines, ballistas, and siege machines.
 - 28 gates (Darwaza), Badaun Darwaza being the greatest.
 - Daulatabad was considered a rival to Delhi.
- **Social Life in Towns:**
 - Populated markets (Bazaars), often with mosques and temples.
 - Public performance spaces, especially on Thursdays, for musicians and dancers.
- **Economy of Towns:**
 - Stored surplus from villages, preventing food shortages.
 - High demand for Indian manufactured finished goods in Europe, West Asia, Southeast Asia.
 - Artisans, traders, merchants made huge profits from long-distance trade.
 - **Demanded Commodities:** Cotton Cloth, Fine Muslins (expensive, worn by rich), Silks, Brocade and Satin, Spices.
- **System of Communication:**
 - Inns and guest houses on trade routes for efficient communication.
 - **Uluq:** Royal horse post, one every four miles.
 - **Dawa:** Foot post for letters and parcels, three every mile (quicker than horse posts). Used to transport fruits from Khurasan Valley.
 - **Travel Time Estimates:** Sind to Delhi (50 days), Multan to Delhi (40 days), Daulatabad to Delhi (40 days), Gwalior to Delhi (10 days).

Francois Bernier in India (1656-1668)

- **Background:** French doctor, political philosopher, historian.
- **European Travelers:** Many Europeans came after Portuguese arrival in 1498 (e.g., Roberto Nobili, Domingo Paes, Jean Baptiste Tavernier, Niccolao Manucci).
- **Bernier's Role:** Resided for 12 years in India. Physician to Dara Shukoh. After Dara's death, worked under Mughal noble Daneshmand Khan.

Accounts of Bernier

- **Comparison with Europe:** Traveled widely, consistently comparing India unfavorably to European development, depicting India as "bleak."
- **Writings:** Dedicated to Louis XIV (French Emperor). Other writings were letters to French officials.
- **Popularity:** Highly popular in Europe due to printing technology.
 - Published in French (1670-71).
 - Translated into English, Dutch, German, Italian within five years.
 - Eight reprints in French by 1725, three in English by 1684. (Arabic/Persian texts often not printed until 1800).

Bernier's Observations

- **Overview:** Detailed, comparative, aimed to influence European policymakers. Emphasized the "Issue of Landownership."
- **Issue of Landownership:**
 - **Indian System (as per Bernier):** Land controlled by the Emperor, no private ownership.
 - **European System:** Land held as private property.
 - **Features of Indian Agrarian Society (Bernier's view):** Lack of long-term investment in agriculture, low agricultural production, less demand for manufactured goods, extreme poverty, excessive exploitation of peasantry.
 - **Mughal Documents' Reality:** Mughal chronicles never stated the state was the *sole* owner. Abu'l Fazl mentioned land revenue as a return for protection. What Europeans saw as rent was actually a crop tax.
- **Depiction of Indian Society:**
 - Full of impoverished people, no middle class.
 - Emperor was ruler of "Beggars and Barbarians."
 - Artisans not benefited; profits appropriated by the state.
 - **Reality of Social Life:**
 - Agrarian structure: Zamindars, Big Peasants, Untouchables.
 - Indian manufactured products in high domestic and global demand.
 - Constant inflow of bullion.
 - Prosperous merchants, artisans, traders.
 - By 17th century, India produced ~25% of global GDP.
- **Depiction of Towns:**

- Low population. Described Mughal towns as "Camp towns" (existing due to imperial patronage, like Agra, Fatehpur Sikri, Shahjahanabad).
- Believed Indian towns lacked social/economic foundations and would ruin without royal patronage.
- **Reality of Indian Towns:**
 - ~15% of population lived in towns (higher than Europe).
 - Many towns flourished due to manufacturing, port business, pilgrimage, not just royal patronage.
 - Urban society included traders, merchants, physicians, teachers, lawyers, painters, architects.
 - Prosperous merchant communities (Mahajan, Seth/Nagarseth in Western India). Professional classes earned from public services, not just royal patronage.
 - Indian towns were not as bleak or stagnant as Bernier depicted.

Impacts of Bernier's Accounts

- Led to two popular ideologies in Europe:
 1. **Oriental Despotism:**
 - Coined by 18th-century French philosopher Montesquieu.
 - **Features:** Asian rulers are authoritative, lack of private property, subjugation of subjects.
 2. **Asiatic Mode of Production:**
 - Proposed by Karl Marx in 19th century.
 - Surplus produce appropriated by the ruler.
 - Villages given autonomy by state in exchange for surplus produce.

Slavery System in Medieval India

- Slaves sold openly in markets (Ibn Battuta purchased slaves as gifts for Sultan Muhammad Bin Tughlaq).
- Often given as gifts or tokens of appreciation.
- **Usage:**
 - Female slaves: entertainment (music, dance), surveillance of nobles.
 - Generally used for domestic labor.
 - **Domestic Slaves:** Prices of female domestic slaves were very low; most households had one or two.

Position of Women

- **Features:**
 - Crucial contribution in agricultural and non-agricultural production.
 - Women from merchant families participated in commercial activities, even taking disputes to court.
 - Sati system was an important factor in women's social condition.
 - Travelers focused on Sati as it was "strange" to them, not women's economic contributions.

Bhakti and Sufi Traditions

- **Aim:** Outline religious developments (8th-18th centuries), ideas of Bhakti/Sufi saints, and historical interpretations.
- **Changes in Mode of Worship:**
 - 1500-800 BCE: Prayers and Oblation.
 - 800 BCE-500 CE: Sacrifices and Rituals.
 - 500 CE Onwards: Devotional and Idol Worship.

Background of Religious Developments

- **Integration of Great and Little Traditions:**
 - Coined by Robert Redfield.
- **Great Tradition:** Sanskrit/Puranic Hinduism.
- **Little Tradition:** Regional Practices.
- **Examples:** Jagannatha Deity idol, Marichi Goddess statue in Buddhism.
- **Differences and Conflicts:**
 - **Tantrism vs. Others:** Tantric puja of Goddess (Shaktism) denied Vedic authority, ignored caste, involved both men and women in mystic activities.
 - **Vedic vs. Puranic:** Vedic deities not in Puranic texts; Vedic religion condemned chanting/sacrificial traditions of Puranic.
 - **Shaivism vs. Vaishnavism:** Debates over supremacy of deities and validation of ideologies.

Early Bhakti Traditions

- **Features:**
 - Introduced by poet-saints of South India.
 - Women and Shudras allowed in the cult.
- **Two forms:**
 - **Saguna Bhakti:** Belief in physical form of God.
 - **Nirguna Bhakti:** Belief in abstract form of God.

The Alvars and Nayanars

- Originated in South India.
- **Alvars:** Devotion to Vishnu (Vaishnava). 12 saints.
- **Nayanars:** Devotion to Shiva (Shaiva). 63 saints.
- **Definition:** Poet-saints who set new standards of devotion through songs and poetry.
- **Important Features:**
 - Composed devotional songs in Tamil.
 - Traveled, singing hymns, identifying shrines where temples were later built.
 - Songs became part of temple rituals.
 - Did not depict distinct religions, but promoted Vaishnavism and Shaivism.
- **Attitude towards Caste System:** Against the caste system, promoted participation from all sects/castes (Brahmana, Shudra, Vaishya, women).
- **Devotional Literature:**
 - **Nalayira Divyaprabandham:** (10th CE) 4000 sacred verses of Alvar saints (considered Tamil Veda). Mentioned 108 shrines (Divya Desam) as abode of Vishnu.
 - **Tevaram:** Poems of 63 Nayanar saints.
- **Women Devotees:**
 - **Andal:** Only female Alvar saint.
 - **Kariakkal Ammaiyar:** Most famous female Nayanar saint. Devotee of Shiva, followed extreme asceticism, renounced social obligations, challenged feminine beauty norms.
- **Relation with State:**
 - Received royal patronage from Cholas, Pandyas, Pallavas.
 - Cholas gave aid to build Vishnu/Shiva temples at identified shrines (e.g., Thanjavur, Chidambaram).
 - Land grants from Pandyas and Pallavas.
 - Kings consecrated saint images in temples (e.g., Chola King Parantaka I installed metal images of Nayanar saints Appar, Sudarar, Sambandar in 945 CE).
- **Why Kings Supported:** Poet-saints had huge popular following; kings patronized them to attract masses, invoke divine support, and proclaim power/status.
- **Conclusion:** Revived Vaishnavism and Shaivism, initiated Bhakti tradition with new methods of music, poetry, and asceticism.

The Virashaiva Tradition (Lingayat)

- **Introduction:** Emerged in 12th century CE in Karnataka.
- **Founder:** Basavanna (a Brahmin).
- **Philosophy:**
 - Rejected heavy rituals, temple worship, concept of rebirth, caste system.
 - Worship Shiva as Ishtalinga (not static Linga).
 - Believed body merges with Shiva after death; buried dead bodies instead of cremating.
 - Treated all humans as equal (God resides in each body).
 - Promoted widow remarriage and post-puberty marriage.
- **Jangam Saints:** Lingayats revered Jangam saints (devotees of Shiva) as their Guru.
- **Sources:**
 - **Vachanas:** Sayings compiled by followers.
 - **Basava Purana:** Biography of Basavanna (13th century) by Palkuriki Somanatha.
- **Weakness:** Highly confined to Karnataka.
- **Other Religious Developments:** Maharashtra (Gyaneshwar, Muktabai), compilation of Bhagvata Purana.

Religious Developments in North India (8th-14th Century)

- **Rajput Rule:** Till 14th century, North India ruled by Rajput Kings who patronized Brahminical philosophies.
- **Lack of Influence:** North India deprived of Alvar, Nayanar, Virashaiva influence.
- **Rise of Siddhas, Naths, Yogis:** Emerged without royal patronage, held influence over people.
 - Challenged orthodox ideas and Vedas.
 - Spoke in ordinary language.
 - Introduced complex forms of Yoga.
- **New Era (Post-13th Century):** Islamic rule (Delhi Sultanate) covered North India, beginning new religious developments.

Advent of Islam in India

- **Timeline:**
 - 711-712 CE: Invasion of Md. Bin Qasim, conquest of Sindh.
 - 10th-11th Century CE: Invasions of Mahmud of Ghazni.
 - 1193 CE: Ghori defeated Prithviraj Chauhan in Second Battle of Tarain.
 - 1206-1526 CE: Delhi Sultanate.
 - 1526-1707 CE: The Great Mughals.
- **The Sharia:** Law governing Muslim community, based on Quran, Hadith, Qiyas (Reasoning), Ijma (Consensus).
- **The Zimmis:** Term for Non-Muslims (Jews, Christians, Hindus) who paid Jaziya for protection.
- **Ulamas:** Islamic scholars who advised kings on religious and political matters.
- **Approach of Muslim Rulers towards Non-Muslims:**
 - Often flexible.
 - Granted land endowments and tax exemptions to non-Muslim religious institutions.
 - Revere Hindu Saints or Yogis (e.g., Mughal Emperor Jahangir with a Yogi).

Popular Practices of Islam

- **The Five Pillars:**
 - **Shahadah:** One God, Allah, and Prophet Muhammad is his Messenger.
 - **Salat:** Five times Namaz (prayer).
 - **Zakat:** Charity.
 - **Sawm:** Roza during Ramzan (fasting).
 - **Hajj:** Pilgrimage to Mecca.
- **Blending of Universal and Regional Features:**
 - Adoption of matriliney and matrilocal residence by Arab Muslim traders in Kerala.
 - Architecture of mosques in Kerala blended with regional styles.
- **Ginan of Khojah Muslims:** Read and translated Islamic scriptures into regional languages.
- **Naming of Communities (by Sanskrit texts):**
 - "Muslim" rarely used. Classified by place of birth.
 - Turkish: Turushka/Shakas.
 - Tajakistani: Tajika.
 - Persian: Parashika.
 - Afghans: Yavanas.
- **Mlechchas:** Community whose people couldn't speak Sanskrit and were unaware of Vedic rituals/traditions.

Emergence and Growth of Sufism

- **Origin:** Emerged in 7th century (death of Muhammad), developed into four orders by 12th century as opposition to extremism.
- **Core Principle:** Personal connection with Supreme God through intense love, meditation, breathing practices, inner purification.
- **Tasawwuf:** Term for Sufism in Islamic texts.
- **Ideology:**
 - Salvation through inner purification and introspection.
 - Intense devotion & love for God (Ishq).
 - Follow Prophet Muhammad's example.
 - Non-violence, love for all creatures.
 - Practice forgiveness and meditation.
- **Khanqah and Silsila:** Two basic pillars for spread.
 - **Khanqah:** Institution where Sufi followers gathered. Regulated by a master (Pir, Murshid, Shaikh) who trained disciples (Murids) and chose successors (Khalifa).
 - **Silsila:** Unbroken chain of relationship between Master and disciples, tracing genealogy from Muhammad.
 - **Four orders in Indian subcontinent:** Chishti, Qadiri, Naqshbandi, Suhrawardi.
- **Ziyarat:** Pilgrimage to the tomb of Sufi saints.
- **Outside the Khanqah:**
 - Some Sufi followers started movements based on mendicancy and extreme asceticism.
 - Defied Sharia, known as **Be-Sharia** (e.g., Qalandariyya, Malang, Madaris).
 - **Ba-Sharia:** Sufi orders that followed Sharia.

The Chishtis in Indian Subcontinent

- **Rapid Growth Reason:** Adapted successfully to local environments and adopted features of Indian devotional tradition.
- **Founder:** Abu Ishaq Sami (from Chist, Afghanistan).
- **Spread in India:** Sheikh Moin-ud-din Chishti. His tomb in Ajmer Sharif is highly visited.

- **Beliefs:** Poverty, without state support; intense devotion to God (Allah).
- **Notable Saints:** Shaikh Moinuddin Chishti, Qutubuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki, Shaikh Fariduddin Ganj-i-Shakar, Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya, Shaikh Nasiruddin Chirag-i-Delhi.
- **Khanqah of Nizamuddin Auliya (Ghiyaspur, Delhi):**
 - Several rooms, large hall (Jamat-i-khana) for prayers.
 - Accommodation for Shaikh, family, disciples, attendants.
 - Open kitchen (Langer) run on **Futuh** (unasked-for charity).
 - **Popular practices:** Bowing before Shaikh, offering water to thirsty, shaving heads of initiates, Yogic exercise, meditation.
- **Nizam as Propagator:** Trained successors to spread Sufism (e.g., Amir Khusrau, Amir Hasan Sijzi, Ziyauddin Barni, Nasiruddin Muhammad).
- **Tomb of Moinuddin Chishti:**
 - Earliest construction by Sultan Gyasuddin Khilji of Malwa.
 - Earliest textual reference of Ziyarat: 14th century AD.
 - First Sultan to visit: Md. Bin Tughlaq.
 - Akbar visited 17 times, offered a Degh (large cooking pot) in 1568.
- **Urs:** Death anniversary of Sufi saints, signifying union of souls with God.
- **Teachings of Gharib Nawaz (Moinuddin Chishti):**
 - Closeness to God through magnanimity (river), kindness (sun), humility (earth).
 - Noble character: beautiful in poverty, content in hunger, cheerful in grief, friendly in hostility.
 - Surest way to escape hell: feed hungry, redress aggrieved, help distressed.
- **Role of Music in Chishti Sufism:**
 - **Methods to remember God:** Dikhr/Zikra (remembrance), Sama (listening/performance of song, dance, instruments).
 - **Qawwali:** Devotional music, important part of Ziyarat.
 - **Amir Khusrau:** Indo-Persian poet, singer, musician, author; "Father of Qawwali." Created Sufi poetry in Hindavi and Persian. Devoted disciple of Nizamuddin Auliya.
- **Language and Communication:**
 - Sama organized in local languages.
 - Sufi saints conversed in Hindavi (Hindustani).
 - In Deccan, poets composed in Dakkhani, sung by women.
 - Sufism in South India grew like Alvars, Nayanars, Lingayats: through music and poetry.
- **Sufism and the State:**
 - Chishtis maintained balanced distance from politics.
 - Accepted donations for public service.
 - Sultans often associated with Sufis due to their crowd support.
 - Rare conflicts (e.g., Nizamuddin Auliya and Gyathuddin Tughlaq).
- **Major Sources:** Works of Amir Khusraw, biography of Moinuddin Chishti (Munis-al-arwah) by Jahanara Begam, works of Ziyauddin Barni, Kashf-ul-Mahjub of Data Ganj Baksh, writings of disciples/visitors.

New Devotional Paths

- **Kabir (15th Century):**
 - Poet-saint born in Varanasi. Disciple of Ramananda (Vaishnava saint).
 - **Verses compiled in:** Kabir Bijak, Kabir Granthawali, Adi Granth.
 - **Teachings:** Emphasis on Bhakti (sincere love/devotion), unified Islam/Hinduism virtues, salvation through Bhakti/good deeds, against idol worship/rituals, rejected caste, emphasized equality, role of Guru.
 - **Controversy:** Authorship of verses debated; religion (Hindu/Muslim) debated.
- **Guru Nanak (1469-1539):**
 - Born in Nankana Sahib (Pakistan), near Ravi River.
 - Advocated **Nirguna Bhakti**.
 - Rejected sacrifices/rituals of Hindus/Muslims.
 - Composed **Shabad** (Hymns) to preach.
 - Emphasized remembering/repeating divine name, promoted collective recitation (Sangat).
 - **Adi Granth Sahib:** Compiled by Fifth Sikh Guru Arjan Dev, included teachings of Guru Nanak, Baba Farid, Kabir, Ravidas. Hymns called Gurubani.
 - **Guru Granth Sahib:** Last Sikh Guru, Guru Govind Singh, added hymns of Guru Tegh Bahadur, named it Guru Granth Sahib. Militarized Sikh cult by establishing Khalsa Panth in 1699.
- **Mirabai (1498-1546):**
 - Princess born in Merta (Marwar), married Prince Bhojraj of Mewar.
 - Recognized Krishna (avatar of Vishnu) as her lover.
 - Defied husband, became wandering saint, composed devotional songs.
 - Disciple of Raidas/Ravidas (saint from Varanasi).

Reconstructing the Histories

- **Sources:** Variety of literary sources, wide range of language and writing styles.
- **Literature of Sufism:** Treatises (manual opinions), Malfuzat (conversations), Maktubat (compilation of letters), Tazkiras (biography of saints).
- **Conclusion:** History of religious developments requires understanding plural sources and dynamic traditions.

Important Terms (Bhakti & Sufi)

- **Hagiography:** Biography of a saint written by followers.
- **Vachanas:** Sayings of Lingayat tradition saints.
- **Ulama:** Islamic scholars advising kings.
- **Sharia:** Law governing Muslim community.
- **Jinan:** Knowledge (Khojah Muslims).
- **Zikrs:** Remembrance of God.
- **Ziyarat:** Pilgrimage to tomb of Sufi saints.
- **Wali:** Sufi considered friend of God, acquiring grace to perform miracles.

An Imperial Capital - Vijayanagara

- **Meaning:** "The city of Victory."
- **Establishment:** Harihara and Bukka in 1336 (earlier served Hoysala Kings).
- **Dynasties:** Four dynasties ruled: Sangama, Suluva, Tuluva, Aravidu.
- **Most Famous Ruler:** Krishnadeva Raya (Tuluva Dynasty).
- **Frontiers:** At peak, stretched from Krishna river to far south of Southern Indian Peninsula.
- **Interactions:** Faced Deccan Sultans and Gajapati rulers of Odisha, leading to exchange of goods, ideas, culture, architecture.
- **Major Sources:** Oral Narratives, Archaeological Finds, Monuments, Inscriptions, Records of Foreign Travelers.

The Discovery of Hampi

- **Hampi:** Modern name for the ruins of Vijayanagara.
- **Discovery:** Colonel Colin Mackenzie in 1800 CE.
- **Colin Mackenzie:** Engineer, Surveyor, Cartographer; First Surveyor General of India. Prepared first survey map based on interaction with Virupaksha Temple priests and Pampa Devi.
- **Research after Mackenzie:**
 - Since 1836, epigraphists collected inscriptions.
 - Combined inscription info with contemporary literature.
- **Hampi's Recognition:**
 - 1976: Declared a site of National Importance.
 - 1986: Declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- **Square Mapping Method:** Used to document details of Vijayanagara from Hampi ruins, figuring out positions of monuments, canals, embankments.

Rayas of Vijayanagara

- **Title:** Kings called themselves "Rayas."
- **Characteristics:** Expansionists, patrons of art and literature.
- **Temple Building:** Built temples in tradition of Cholas and Hoysalas.
- **Economy:** Encouraged trade for wealth.
- **Contemporary Name:** Vijayanagara Empire known as "Karnataka Samrajyamu."
- **Diversity:** Managed diversity well.

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Trade in Vijayanagara

- **Key Element:** Foreign trade for prosperity.
- **Foreign Trade Partners:** Arabs, Turks, Portuguese.
- **Traded Commodities:**
 - **Imported:** Horses from Arabia and Central Asia.
 - **Exported:** Spices, precious stones, textiles.
 - Portuguese involved in musket trade.
- **Benefits:** Huge revenue, prosperity, foreign exchange.
- **Importance:** Krishnadevaraya mentioned trade importance in his book *Amuktamalyada*.

Peak and Decline of Vijayanagara

- **Dynasties & Periods:**
 - Sangama (1336-1485)
 - Suluva (1485-1503)
 - Tuluva (1503-1542)
 - Aravidu (1542-1646)
- **Zenith:** Rule of Krishnadeva Raya (third ruler of Tuluva Dynasty).
- **Krishnadeva Raya (Andhra Bhoja, Lord of Kannada Empire):**
 - **Military Conquests:** Conquered Raichur Doab (1512), subdued Gajapati Rulers of Odisha (1514), defeated Sultan of Bijapur (Ismail Adil Shah) in Battle of Raichur (1520).
 - **Art & Literature:** Patronized Telugu, Tamil, Kannada literature. His reign known as Golden Age for Telugu Literature (era of Ashtadiggaj - eight poets). Wrote texts in Telugu (*Amuktamalyada*) and Sanskrit (*Jambvati Kalyana*).
 - **Religion:** Rebuilt/innovated temples (Virupaksha, Vitthala, Hazara Rama). Founded Nagalapuram. Promoted ceremonies like Dussehra.
 - **Sources:** Contemporary literature, ~2,000 inscriptions.
- **Post-Krishnadeva Raya Era:**
 - Nayakas (Military Chiefs) rebelled.
 - Empire fell under Aravidu Dynasty, with Chief Minister Aliya Rama Raya as de-facto ruler.
 - **Battle of Talikota (1565):** Collective army of Deccan Sultanates defeated Rama Raya's army (also known as Battle of Rakshasi Tangadi).
 - **Consequences:** Mighty blow, marked decline. City sacked and plundered. Capital shifted from Vijayanagara to Penugonda, then Chandragiri.
- **Relations with Deccan Sultans:** Not always hostile; cooperated when needed. Krishnadevaraya supported claimants in Deccan Sultanate; Sultan of Bijapur intervened in succession after Krishnadevaraya. Tricky policy of Aliya Rama Raya led to Talikota.

Nayakas of Vijayanagara Empire

- **Definition:** Military chiefs controlling forts, with armed support. Moved in search of fertile land. Many submitted to kings.
- **Language:** Spoke Telugu and Kannada.
- **Post-Talikota:** Many Nayakas carved out their own kingdoms (e.g., Madurai Nayakas built Gopuram of Meenakshi Temple).
- **Amara Nayakas:** Military commanders given land grants by Vijayanagara kings.
 - Authorized to collect taxes from peasants, craftsmen, traders.
 - Kept a portion for army maintenance, submitted rest to king.
 - Maintained efficient, disciplined army.
 - Sent annual tributes, appeared in court to express loyalty.
 - Transferred to keep them under control.
- **Similar to Iqta System** of Delhi Sultanate (introduced by Sultan Iltutmish).

The City of Vijayanagara

- **Major Sources:** Inscriptions of Kings and Nayakas, Accounts of Foreign Travelers.
- **15th Century:** Nicole De Conti (Italy), Abdur Razaqq (Persia), Afanassi Nikitin (Russia).

- **16th Century:** Duarte Barbosa (Portugal), Domingo Paes (Portugal), Fernao Nuniz (Portugal).

Water Resources

- **Necessity:** Semi-arid region, crucial to manage water for irrigation, gardening, domestic, and temple consumption.
- **Features:**
 - Natural basins formed by Tungabhadra river.
 - Embankments along streams led to reservoirs.
 - Many tanks built to collect rainwater and reservoir water (e.g., Kamalapuram Tank).
 - Canals supplied water to tanks and city.
- **Hiriy Canal:** Built by Sangama rulers, drew water from reservoirs/tanks to agricultural fields and Royal Center.
- **Domestic Water:** Wells, Rainwater Tanks, Temple Tanks.
- **Kamalapuram Tank:** (15th century) Collected rainwater, supplied water for irrigation and Royal Center.

Fortification of the City

- **Description:** Extreme fortification for security.
- **Seven Lines:** According to Abdur Razzaq, seven lines of fortification.
- **Features:**
 - Encircled agricultural fields, hinterland, and forests.
 - Outermost line linked with natural granite hills.
 - No masonry work or mortar; walls made of wedge-shaped stones held by rubbles.
 - Agricultural fields, gardens, houses located between inner walls.
- **Why Agricultural Tracts Fortified:** To avoid food shortage during sieges.
- **Inner Fortifications:** Urban complex by second line, Royal Center by third line.
- **Entrances:** Well-guarded, some built with Indo-Islamic Architecture.
- **Roads:** Built through valleys to avoid mountains; connected gateways to temples and bazaars.

The Urban Core

- **Features:** Huge markets, residences of ordinary people (less archaeological evidence).
- **North-Eastern Corner:** Evidence of broken Chinese porcelain, suggesting a hub for rich traders and Muslim population.
- **Shrines:** Dotted with shrines, tombs, mosques. Mosques/tombs built like temple mandapas, not Indo-Persian/Indo-Turkish style.

The Royal Centre

- **Location:** South-Western Part of settlement.
- **Features:** Over 60 temples (including Hazara Rama Temple), ~30 palaces. Temples in masonry, palaces in perishable materials (wood).
- **King's Palace:** Largest building, surrounded by high double walls. (Archaeologists not certain if it housed royalty).
- **Distinctive Platforms:**
 - **Audience Hall:** High platform with closely spaced wooden pillars, multi-storey (ruins of staircase). Speculated for royal darbar.
 - **Mahanavami Dibba:** 11,000 sq ft, 40 ft high. Wooden structure on top. Base decorated with carvings. Used as stage during Durga Puja/Navaratri ceremonies.
 - **Dussehra Ceremony Features:** Image worship, state horse worship, buffalo sacrifices, dance, wrestling, processions. Nayakas/subordinate kings presented before Raya, offered gifts/tributes.
- **Lotus Mahal:** Beautiful building, Indo-Islamic architecture inspired. Colin Mackenzie speculated it was a council chamber. (Utility uncertain).
- **Hazara Rama Temple:** Used by Royal family. Built by Sangama dynasty ruler Devaraya II. Walls sculpted with Ramayana scenes.

The Sacred Centre

- **Location:** Northern end of the settlement.
- **Religious Traditions:** Monkey kingdom of Vali/Sugreev (Ramayana), story of Pampa Devi and Lord Virupaksha. Many Jain temples.
- **Association of Kings and Temples:**
 - Temple building as a way to gain support and recognition.
 - Kings identified with deity to associate with divine.
 - Temple as a center of learning.
 - Rayas claimed to rule on behalf of Lord Virupaksha. All royal orders signed in name of "Shri Virupaksha." Adopted title "Hindu Suratrana."
- **Dravidian Temple Architecture:** Gopuram and Mandapa.
 - **Gopuram:** Gateway. Kings built massive gopurams to exhibit imperial authority (e.g., Krishnadeva Raya built East Gopuram of Virupaksha Temple).
 - **Mandapa:** Structures inside temple complex (pavilion/corridor). Used for dance, music, drama, ceremonial weddings. Pillars decorated with sculptures.
- **Virupaksha Temple:** Built over centuries (9th-10th CE onwards), major contributions by Vijayanagara rulers. Hall in front of main shrine and eastern gopuram built by Krishnadeva Raya. Halls used for specific purposes (dance, music, drama, ceremonial weddings, swing pavilion for deity). Special deity images used for swing/performances.
- **Vithala Temple:** Dedicated to Vishnu. Unique Chariot shrine. Stone slabs laid inside. 56 musical pillars (sound differently when struck). (After 1565, Nayakas continued building huge Gopurams/Mandapas).

Advantages and Limitations of Monuments as Sources

- **Advantages:**
 - Insights into defense requirements and military preparedness.
 - Spread of ideas.
 - Perspectives of builders.
- **Limitations:**
 - Cannot trace perspectives of ordinary masses.
 - Ignores details about laborers involved in construction.

Peasants, Zamindars, and State

- **Rural Hierarchy:**
 - **Mughal Authority:** Mughal officials (Amil Guzar, Amin, Chaudhary) in local administration.
 - **Zamindars:** Assisted Mughal administration.
 - **Peasants:** Primary unit of rural society.

Peasants and Agricultural Production

- **Major Sources:**
 - **Mughal Chronicles:** Ain-i-Akbari (details on agricultural arrangements, revenue collection; "view from top").
 - **Regional Records:** Gujarat, Maharashtra, Rajasthan (17th-18th CE) records (agricultural arrangements beyond Mughal empire).
 - **Records of EIC:** Helpful for medieval Indian rural life.
- **Peasants and Their Lands:**
 - **Names:** Raiyat, Muzarian, Asami, Kisan.
 - **Tasks:** Seasonal (tilling, sowing, harvesting), agro-based goods (sugar, oil).
 - **Types:**
 - **Khud Kashta:** Residents cultivating their own village land.
 - **Pahi Kashta:** Cultivated land of others on contractual basis (by choice for lower taxes, or compulsion due to no land).
 - **Economic Condition:** Average North Indian peasant had <1 pair of bullocks and 2 ploughs. Regional variation: 6 acres in Gujarat = affluent; 5 acres in Bengal = average, 10 acres = rich.
 - **Demarcation:** Needed due to individual ownership; used raised earth, bricks, thorns.
- **Irrigation and Technology:**
 - **Irrigation:** Monsoons were backbone. Artificial techniques (ropes, wheels, ox). State support (e.g., Shahnahar of Punjab).
 - **Technology:** Wooden plough with iron tip, drill for seeding pulled by oxen, hoe with iron blade/wooden handle.
- **Crops in Medieval India:**
 - **Cropping Pattern:** Two major cycles - Rabi (Spring), Kharif (Autumn).
 - **Do Fasla:** Producing two crops a year.
 - **Stats:** Agra (39 crops), Delhi (43 crops), Bengal (50 crops).
 - **Jins-i-Kamil:** Commercial crops (sugarcane, cotton, oil seeds). Deccan produced most cotton, Bengal most sugar.

- **Foreign Crops:** Maize (Spain/South Africa), Tomatoes, Potatoes, Chillies (America), Papaya, Pineapple (New World).
- **Tobacco:** Introduced during Akbar's reign, banned by Jahangir.
- **Agriculture and Population Growth:** Flexibility in agriculture contributed to population growth (~50 million increase from 1600-1800).

The Village Community

- **Composition:** Cultivators, Panchayat, Headman.
- **Caste and Rural Ambience:**
 - **Social Structure:** Heterogeneous cultivators from various castes/communities. Agricultural laborers and menials (Majur) in good numbers.
 - **Social Differences:** Halalkhoran (scavengers) lived outside village (Muslims). Mallahzadas (boatmen) treated as slaves (Bihar). Direct correlation between caste, poverty, social status at lower levels.
 - **Middle Level Differences:** No direct correlation. Rajputs/Jats as peasants in Marwar. Gaurava (Vrindavan cultivator) claimed Rajput status. Ahir, Gujars, Malis rose due to cattle rearing/horticulture. Sadgops, Kaivartas (fishing caste) became peasants in Eastern India.
- **Panchayat and Headmen:**
 - **Panchayat Structure:** Assembly of village elders. Heterogeneous in mixed-caste villages, but menials/agricultural workers not represented. Decisions binding.
 - **Panchayat Functions:** Help in calamities, build infrastructure (canals), ensure caste system obedience, resolve disputes.
 - **Financial Resources:** Common financial pool maintained by villagers.
 - **Headman (Mandal/Muqaddam):** Chosen by elders, election ratified by Zamindar. No fixed tenure. Supervised village accounts (assisted by Patwari). Oversaw villager conduct, prevented offenses against caste system. Often misused position, under-assessed own tax.
 - **Jati Panchayats:** Each Jati had its own. Arbitrated civil disputes. State respected decisions (except criminal).
 - **Local Disputes:** Peasants complained about extortionate taxation/unpaid labor (Begar). Demanded remuneration. Solution: compensation or vacating village.
- **Village Artisans:**
 - **Introduction:** ~25% rural population in Maharashtra were artisans. Provided pottery, metal working, furniture, jewelry.
 - **Remuneration:** Share of harvest, sometimes land (cultivable waste).
 - **Jajmani System (Bengal):** Artisans paid daily allowances and diet money.
 - **Note:** Artisans and peasants often same persons (peasants performed artisanal functions off-season).
- **Equality in Rural Society:**
 - Individual ownership, deep inequities. Powerful individuals dominated.
 - Cash in trade gave advantage to artisans and commercial farmers.
 - **Role of Shroff:** Village bankers, maintained/regulated money flow (mentioned by Jean Baptiste Tavernier).

Women in Rural Society

- **Women in Field and Craft Production:**
 - **Field:** Sowed, weeded, threshed, winnowed. Biases: couldn't touch plough/potter wheel during menstruation (Western India), couldn't enter betel leaf fields (Bengal).
 - **Craft:** Spinning yarn, sifting, kneading clay, embroidery. Commercial products required more women's effort.
- **Dominance of Women (or lack thereof):**
 - Household dominated by males, women under strict control.
 - Huge punishments for infidelity.
 - Male infidelity not always punished. Panchayats/state ensured women got compensation.
- **Prevalence of Bride Price:** In many peasant/artisanal communities due to importance in agriculture/craft, need for population extension, shortage of women.
- **Women Inheritance:** In landed gentry, women had right to inherit property. Women (including widows) actively participated in land market as sellers. Women Zamindars known in Bengal (e.g., Rajshahi Zamindari led by women).

Forests and Tribes

- **The Forest Dwellers:**
 - **Location:** East India, Central India, parts of Western Ghats, Deccan Plateau.

- **Role:** Refuge for troublemakers.
- **Life:** Termed "Jangli" in Mughal texts. Livelihood from forest produce, hunting, shifting cultivation.
- **Seasonal Activities:** Spring (collecting produce), Summer (fishing), Monsoon (cultivation), Autumn/Winter (hunting).
- **Interference of State:**
 - **Peshakash:** Tribute in forest produce (e.g., elephants for war).
 - **Hunt:** Enabled emperor to travel, attend to people's problems. Common theme in Mughal paintings.
- **Impact of Trade:**
 - **Demand:** Honey, beeswax, gum lac, elephants.
 - **Traders:** Lohanis (Punjab) engaged in overland trade between India/Afghanistan and within Punjab.
 - **Exports from Mountains:** Gold, Copper, Lead, Musk, Honey, Long Pepper, Ginger, Wax, Woolen Cloths, Wooden Ware.
 - **Imports to Mountains:** Coloured Cloths, Amber, Salt, Gum, Ornaments, Glass, Pottery.
- **Social and Cultural Changes:**
 - **Rise of Tribal Kingdoms:** Chieftains became kings, recruited armies (e.g., Sindh tribes: 6,000 cavalry, 7,000 infantry).
 - **Paik System (Ahom kings of Assam):** Land given in exchange for military services.
 - **Rise of Islam:** Many North/North-West Indian tribes adopted Islam due to Sufism.

The Zamindars

- **Origin:** Conquest, colonization of lands, transfer of rights, state order, purchase.
- **Important Features:** Did not directly participate in agricultural production. Upper part of social pyramid. Status determined by caste, Khidmat (services for state).
- **Sources of Power:** Milkiyat (proprietary rights), State Services (Khidmat), control over military resources, control over forts.
- **Monetization of Agriculture:**
 - Lent loans to peasants.
 - Sold their produce for cash.
 - Established markets (Hats).
 - Sold/purchased Zamindari for cash.
- **Relations with Peasantry:**
 - Exploitative, but also seen as patrons/guardians.
 - Bhakti saints did not portray them as exploitative.
 - Peasants supported Zamindars in many agrarian revolts of 17th century.

The Land Revenue System

- **Collection of Land Revenue:**
 - Main source of state income. Diwan headed department.
 - **Process:** Jama (Assessment) → Hasil (Collection). Amil Guzar (Collector) responsible.
 - Akbar emphasized cash collection. Collection often fell behind assessment.
- **Measurements of Lands:**
 - Ain-i-Akbari compiled aggregated lands during Akbar.
 - Both cultivated and cultivable lands measured.
 - Aurangzeb ordered annual records of cultivators in 1665. (Note: Not all land in subcontinent measured).
- **Classification of Lands under Akbar:** Four categories.
 - **Polaz:** Annually cultivated, never fallow.
 - **Parauti:** Left for some time to recover.
 - **Chachar:** Left for 3-4 years.
 - **Banjar:** Left for 5+ years.
- **Calculation of Royal Dues:**
 - Polaz and Parauti classified into Good, Middling, Bad.
 - 1/3rd of (Good + Middling + Bad) = Medium Produce.
 - 1/3rd of Medium Produce = Royal Dues.

The Flow of Silver

- **Politics in 16th and 17th Century:** Four large empires (Mughal, Safavid, Ottoman, Ming) led to political stability, boosting trade from China to Mediterranean. (Gunpowder Empires: Ottoman + Safavid + Mughals).
- **Expansion of Trade:**
 - Reasons: Political stability, Voyages of Discovery, Opening of New World (America).
 - Asia (India specifically) exported huge goods, leading to silver inflow.
- **Impact of Flow of Silver:** Stability in metal currency, minting of many coins, smooth circulation of currency. (Silver Rupaya of Akbar's/Aurangzeb's Era).

The Ain-i-Akbari

• Introduction:

- Third volume of Akbar Nama.
- Authored by Abu'l Fazl.
- Completed in 1598, revised five times.

• **Information:** Detailed layout of court, administration, army, revenue, literary/cultural/religious traditions, Akbar's departments.

• **Importance:** For Mughal empire (knowing people/customs), for audience (information on Mughal empire, contemporary people/society).

• **Sources Referred:** Official reports, narrative of Akbar's actions, details from interrogating royal family/servants, rough notes/memoranda, notes of ex-servicemen.

• **Classification of Ain:** Five volumes.

• **Manzil Abadi:** Imperial Household/maintenance, Imperial Mint, Trade/Business, Art/Paintings.

• **Sipah Abadi:** Military/Civil Administration, biographies of imperial officials, learned men, poets, artists.

• **Mulk Abadi:** Fiscal side, quantitative revenue info. Account of 12 Provinces (Subas) with detailed info on administrative divisions (Sarkar, Pargana, Qila). Arazi/Zamin-i-Paimuda (measured land), Naqadi (cash revenue), Suyurghal (revenue grants), Zamindars (caste, troops).

• **4th Volume:** Laws and social conditions.

• **5th Volume:** Sayings, observations, wisdom of Akbar.

• **Limitations of Ain:**

- "View from top," carries Mughal agenda.
- Arithmetic errors.
- Non-uniform data collection.
- No information on price/wage rates.

• **Difference from other texts:** Not confined to politics/wars/succession disputes. Detailed info on India and Indians. Despite limitations, a key source for Medieval India.

Important Terms (Peasants & Zamindars)

• **Raiyat/Muzarian:** Peasant.

• **Jins-i-Kamil:** Commercial Crops.

• **Pargana:** Administrative subdivision of Mughal Province.

• **Peshkash:** Form of tribute collected by Mughal state.

• **Amil Guzar:** Revenue Collector under Mughal Empire.

• **Amin:** Official ensuring imperial regulations in province.

• **Jama:** Assessed amount of Revenue.

• **Hasil:** Collected amount of Revenue.

• **Zamin-i-Paimuda:** Measured Land.

• **Muqaddam:** Headman of village.



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